



United States
Attorney's Office
Northern District of Florida



Fraudulent Billing Scheme Targeted in False Claims Act Complaint Against Physical Therapy Practice

Friday, June 6, 2025

For Immediate Release

U.S. Attorney's Office, Northern District of Florida

PENSACOLA, FLORIDA - The United States has filed a complaint under the False Claims Act ("FCA") against Absolute Physical & Aquatic Therapy, LLC; Chipley Physical Therapy, LLC; Ruben Laurel; and Lorrie Laurel, announced U.S. Attorney John P. Heekin. The complaint, filed in the U.S. District Court for Northern District of Florida, alleges that the Defendants billed the Government for services that Defendant Lorrie Laurel, a physical therapist, performed while she was abroad.

Defendant Chipley Physical Therapy, LLC ("CPT") provides outpatient physical and aquatic therapy services across the Florida panhandle in Chipley, Marianna, and Bonifay, and is owned and operated by Defendants Ruben and Lorrie Laurel. Defendant Absolute Physical & Aquatic Therapy ("APAT") is a physical therapy billing company owned and operated by Defendant Ruben Laurel.

The government's complaint alleges Defendants knowingly submitted false claims for payment in violation of the FCA by billing the government for services while Defendant Lorrie Laurel was out of the country and on cruises in Mexico, Jamaica, Aruba, and the Bahamas between July 2019 and March 2024. More specifically, the complaint alleges Defendants submitted 613 claims for payment to the United States for services Defendant Lorrie Laurel allegedly performed at CPT while she was abroad.

U.S. Attorney Heekin said: "This lawsuit demonstrates our firm commitment to hold healthcare providers accountable for fraudulent billing and fulfills the promise of President Donald J. Trump and Attorney General Pam Bondi to aggressively root out fraud, waste, and abuse. Healthcare providers who are fraudulently charging the federal government for medical services not rendered will be vigorously pursued by our office."

The lawsuit is captioned *United States ex rel. Ariel Bowen v. Absolute Physical & Aquatic Therapy, LLC, et al.*, Case No. 5:21-cv-236-TKW-MJF (N.D. Fla.), and is being handled by the U.S. Attorney's Office for

the Northern District of Florida. The U.S. Department of Health and Human Services provided substantial assistance in the investigation.

The United States is represented in this matter by Assistant U.S. Attorneys Mary Ann Couch and Marie Moyle for the Northern District of Florida.

The claims asserted against defendants are allegations only and there has been no determination of liability.

The United States Attorney’s Office for the Northern District of Florida is one of 94 offices that serve as the nation’s principal litigators under the direction of the Attorney General. To access public court documents online, please visit the [U.S. District Court for the Northern District of Florida](#) website. For more information about the United States Attorney’s Office, Northern District of Florida, visit <http://www.justice.gov/usao/fln/index.html>.

Updated June 6, 2025

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